Chapter 3: The Amirs of Mīrzās

1 The Bangash District is the traditional homeland of Bangash a tribe of ethnic Pashtuns. It stretches from Kohat to Tall and Spīn Ghar in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Pakistan, touching the smaller parts of Paktia, Afghanistan. The people from this tribe also live in Uttar Pradesh, India majorly in the city of Farrukhabad. The Bangash are also settled in large numbers in Uttar Pradesh, India, especially in the city of Farrukhabad (Iranica). If folk etymology is to be trusted, the name Bangash is derived from bon-kash, Persian for 'root destroyer', implying the fact that the brave Bangash during battles, won't stop until they had annihilated the enemy completely (Wylly, 2008).

Unlike other Pashtuns, the Bangash primarily follow Shia Islam (Iranica). They mostly speak a northern variety of Pashto like Afridi Pashto. Origin of tribe has multiple narratives. Of all the narratives, the most popular one goes this way:

> *The Bangash tribe descended from Ismail, a governor of Multan. It is said that Khalid ibn al-Walid was eleventh generation of Ismail. It is said that Khalid was the commander of Prophet Muhammad (Wylly, 2008). The legend states that Ismail moved from Multan to settle in Gardez, Paktia, and he married with a girl from Farmul in Urgun, Paktika. Ismail had two sons, Gār and Sāmil, who were the progenitors of the modern Gari and Samilzai clans of the Bangash, respectively (Iranica).*

Now, the reception of this legend is quite interesting. Although Historians reject this account stating it to be highly ambiguous, the Bangash are recognized as 'of Arab origin' in British records. It gets further interesting as the same Historians who see the legend as ambiguous piece of history accept that the Gar and Samel factions originated within the Bangash and slowly spread to the surrounding tribes of the Soleyman range. We also have Pashtun folklore which trace their origin back to Qais Abdur Rashid. Qais was a close confidant of Khalid.

2 Zamindawar is a region of great historical significance in Afghanistan. Zamindwar is quite large and extremely fertile with Helmand River being main source of irrigation. It is in the greater territory of the northern stretch of Helmand Province and covers the approximate area of modern-day Baghran, Musa Qala, Naw Zad, Kajaki and Sangin. It has been known as the district of hills very well populated. Musa Qala, standing on the banks of a river named